

INSIDE THE INDUSTRY

# "BE CAREFUL" IS NOT A WIRE FRAUD PROTOCOL.

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Real estate fraud losses just hit a record 275 million dollars.

**D.J. Paris**  
Keeping It Real Podcast

**kale**  
Realty

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**MORE THAN ONE IN  
FIVE BUYERS GET A  
SUSPICIOUS  
MESSAGE DURING  
CLOSING.**

Most never got more than a warning to watch out for it.



## THE SCAM DOESN'T TARGET YOU. IT TARGETS YOUR CLIENT.

The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center logged more than 275 million dollars in real estate related fraud losses across 12,368 victims in 2025, up from 173 million dollars and 9,359 victims the year before.

CertifID's 2026 State of Wire Fraud report found more than one in five consumers report receiving suspicious communications during a real estate closing, and AI is making those messages harder to catch. A buyer who loses a down payment to a cloned email doesn't remember being told to be careful. They remember who never gave them a number to call first.



# HAND THIS TO EVERY BUYER AT ONBOARDING:

- 1 Don't rely on a spoken warning at the start of the transaction.**  
A verbal "watch out for scams" is forgotten before the first wire ever moves.
- 2 Do put it in writing at onboarding.**  
"I will never send wiring instructions by email or text. If you get any, call me first at this number before you move money."
- 3 Do give them the number on paper, not just in a text thread.**  
A saved contact survives a spoofed inbox. A buried text does not.



## THE TAKEAWAY

**THE WRITTEN  
CALLBACK RULE IS  
THE PROTOCOL.  
THE WARNING WAS  
NEVER ENOUGH.**

Hand it over before the first wire, not after the first scare.